

The bane of most laptop users is the lack of really long battery life

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Laptops are expensive gadgets made for mobility. Generally, they are not very tough, and are not known to take too well to being mishandled.

If you do end up messing your laptop, even the smallest of repairs will set you back by thousands of rupees. Read on to learn how to care for your laptop.

We have also included some important pointers you need to stick to before, during and after using your laptop.

Clean It Right

Since your laptop is such an expensive gadget (falling prices notwithstanding), be extremely careful while cleaning the screen. Make sure the cloth is very soft, and has no imprints or monograms on it, as these may scratch the screen.

Also ensure that the cloth is lint-free, else it will leave fibres on the screen, and make the display unclear. Make sure you don't spray any cleaner directly on the screen. Instead, spray onto the cleaning cloth, and allow the cloth to capture the dirt and contaminants.

Choosing The Spray

The screen is the most expensive component of your laptop. Adequate care must be taken while choosing the cleaning spray. Harsh sprays could turn the screen yellow, and may even cause cracking. Use plain water or vinegar to clean the screen.

Placing The Laptop

Hard drives work on the property of magnetic flux, so any electrical field may damage the hard disk and the

data on it. Make sure your laptop is at least 13 cm away from any electrical appliance that generates a strong magnetic field—such as a microwave oven.

Give It A Breather

If you have just shut down your laptop, give it 30 seconds before you start it up again. This ensures that the hard drive has spun down, and is not subjected to sudden switching on and off.

Data Backup

Always back up your data. Laptops are mobile devices, and are susceptible to breakage. Also, it's possible that the hard disk simply crashes. Remember, you can *never* back up too frequently.

Laptop Battery Care

The bane of most laptop users is the lack of a really long battery life. There are three main types of laptop batteries:

- ☐ Nickel-Cadmium (Ni-Cd)
- ☐ Nickel Metal Hydride (Ni-MH)
- ☐ Lithium Ion (Li-ion).

Nickel-Cadmium

This type of battery must be fully discharged and then fully recharged every few

weeks. If you don't do this, it will quickly lose battery life due to what is known as the 'memory effect'.

The memory effect means if you don't follow the above procedure, your battery will only charge up to the percentage of the last charge. For instance, if you discharge it to 30 per cent, it will only charge up the remaining 70 per cent.

Do this repeatedly, and the 30 per cent will become unusable, giving you an effective 70 per cent charge even though the indicator will still show a 100 per cent charge each time you charge it.

Nickel Metal Hydride

Ni-MH batteries are similar to Ni-Cd batteries, although they are less susceptible to the memory effect. They also have a higher capacity.

Lithium Ion

These are the latest type of batteries, and have no real problems as far as the memory effect is concerned.

The problem with these is that they lose their effectiveness if overcharged or left for a long time with a full charge. Always discharge these batteries if you're going to be storing them away.



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Thought is only the first step.